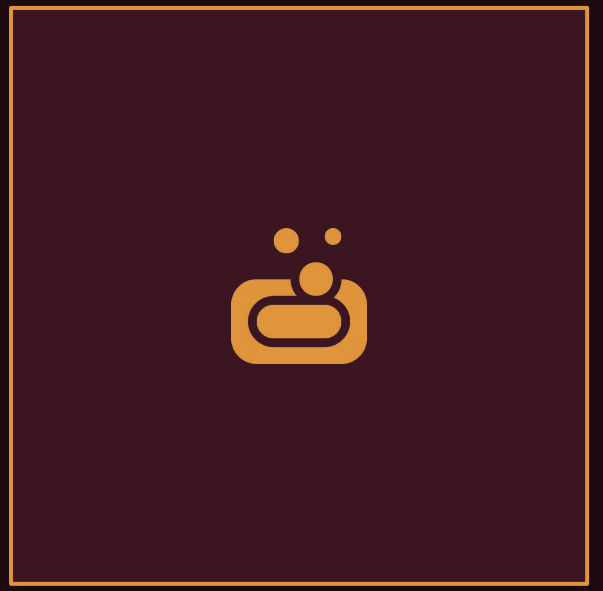
THE "GREATER-GOOD" TRAP

When a shared-sounding goal hides a choice someone made

A VADEMECUM



"For the greater good": the phrase that turns a contested trade-off into a consensus no one actually voted on.

What it is

Presenting a contested value trade-off as if it were a goal everyone already shares, so no one has to defend the choice or name who pays.

THE CLAIM

- "It benefits everyone"
- "The good outweighs the cost"
- "Any reasonable person agrees"
- "There's no real alternative"

WHAT'S HIDDEN

- Whose good, exactly
- Who carries the cost
- Who decided, and how
- The options never tabled

The tell is the missing question: a real greater good can say whose good, at what cost, and who chose.

Why it works

It isn't just rhetoric. It's persuasive in three specific ways.



It sounds like consensus

It launders a choice into an agreement. Framed as a shared goal, a contested decision slips through without a vote.



It shames dissent

Objecting to "the greater good" makes you the selfish one. The framing puts the burden on whoever questions the cost.



It builds a ratchet

Powers taken "just for the emergency" rarely go back. The infrastructure outlives the crisis that justified it.

Further reading: Shoshana Zuboff, The Age of Surveillance Capitalism (2019).

The heart of it: whose good, at whose cost?

Every "greater good" is a distribution: benefits to some, costs to others.

A shared good

- Benefits and costs fall on the same people.
- Accepted by those who carry them.
- Legitimate, and rarely needs the phrase.

A transferred cost

- Benefits go to one group; costs to another who never agreed.
- This is the one the phrase exists to hide.

"For the greater good," said to the group bearing the cost, is the whole move: a transfer dressed as a consensus.

The trap in the critique

Be careful: not every collective trade-off is a con.



Some greater-good calls are real and necessary: public health, safety, taxation. Dismissing every one as manipulation is its own cynicism, and it paralyses genuine collective action.



So the skill isn't rejecting the phrase. It's asking whether the trade-off is named and owned, or smuggled. Genuine collective goods survive the questions; disguised transfers don't.

The test: consensus or disguise?

Don't ask whether it sounds good. Ask whether it names its price and its owner.

Whose good?

Can they say precisely who benefits, or only "everyone"?

At whose cost?

Is the group bearing the cost named, and did they agree?

Who chose?

Is there an accountable decision-maker who can be asked why?

What's the exit?

When the emergency ends, does the power end too, or is there a sunset with teeth?

Every question is an accountability question. A greater good that can't name its price is usually protecting neither.

Vademecum — the essentials

Definition

A contested trade-off dressed as a goal everyone shares, so no one defends the choice.

Its purpose

To pass a decision without a vote and without a named cost.

Its trick

Turns "who pays and who decides" into "don't you want what's good?"

The caution

Not all collective goods are cons: dismissing every one paralyses real action.

The real skill

Not rejecting the phrase, but telling a shared good from a transferred cost.

The test

Whose good, at whose cost, who chose, what's the exit? Name the price, or it's a disguise.

The phrase meant to unite becomes the instrument for deciding unaccountably.